

the previous track or skip the current one. Like any good thing, though, you were afflicted with far too many of them. GNOME had switched from a single panel to two of them, to accommodate all you may want to access easily on the panel. Ubuntu switched back to one, particularly for the smaller netbook interfaces. Ubuntu also introduced indicator applets to consolidate some of the applications using the notification area, under a common icon.

GNOME Shell has a hidden panel (a message tray) at the bottom, for some of the icons that would have been in the notification area. As I tried to figure out what happened to various icons that used to end up in the notification area, I was reminded of a scene in 'Five Easy Pieces', in which Jack Nicholson wants bread, but the restaurant does not have bread on the menu. So he orders a chicken sandwich, and asks the waitress to hold the chicken, the mayonnaise, the lettuce, ... This scene certainly reflected my frustration at trying to cope with solutions that, at least to me, do not seem simpler or more intuitive. I can certainly assert that my mother would not be able to use them, and I wasn't comfortable with them either—and all this fuss over a feature that's quite incidental. I must be missing something.

You may search for the controversies around *libappindicator* as used in Unity. (A few links: <http://blogs.gnome.org/bolsh/2011/03/07/has-gnome-rejected-canonical-help/>, <http://aseigo.blogspot.com/2011/03/collaborations-demise.html>)

The comments in this Telepathy ticket make for interesting reading, to get a perspective from the application's developers: <https://trac.transmissionbt.com/ticket/3685>. The following conversation about the Ayatana project bringing the Unity interface to OpenSUSE 11.4, and the notification area protocol of GNOME Shell, may also be of interest: <http://lwn.net/Articles/421239/>.

Back to Notification Area icons

One group that will not be supported by GNOME Shell or Unity are the GNOME Panel applets. GNOME 3 will provide a way to migrate the applets to GNOME 3; however, they will only be available in the fall-back mode.

The next group is user applications that minimise to the notification area. These are expected to use the desktop notification specifications, <http://www.galago-project.org/specs/notification/0.9/>. KDE 4's notification system also



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